

RÜPPELL'S VULTURE

Gyps rueppelli

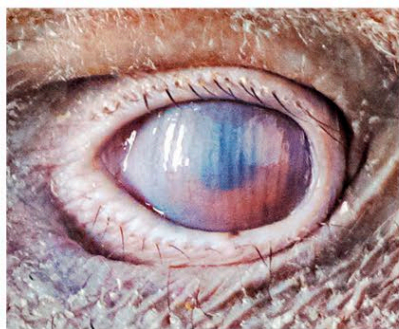
One of the iconic scavengers of the African plains, from Senegal east to Sudan and Tanzania, Rüppell's vulture flies so high in roaming for food that its blood is specially adapted to capture oxygen in the thin air. This vulture patrols dry mountainous terrain, leaving its cliff-top roost sites in early morning to rise on updrafts instead of thermals. It uses acute vision to find carcasses and will wait patiently – days, if necessary – for predators to leave a kill. Like most vultures, it eats soft, rotting flesh and offal. However, its longer neck means it can reach deeper into corpses than many of its competitors – gorging its fill until, with some difficulty, it returns to the skies.



SIZE 85–97 cm (34–38 in)
HABITAT Gorges in dry, open country
DISTRIBUTION North and East Africa
DIET Carrion

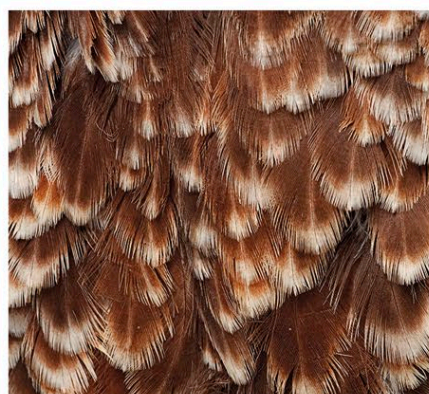
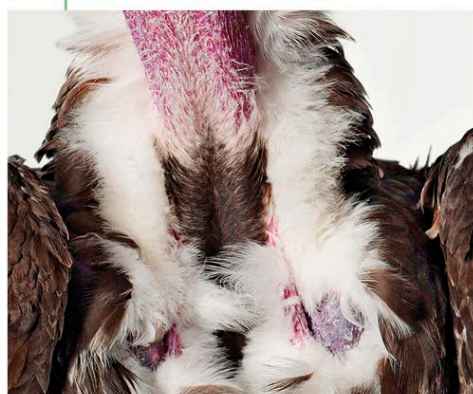
> THIRD EYELID

A typical feature of birds, this membrane cleans the surface of the eye, and may help protect against flying debris during frenzied feeding.



✓ WHITE COLLAR

White fluffy feathers encircling the base of the neck form a ruff. This may be discoloured with dust and blood from carcasses.



< PLUMAGE

Beneath the patterned feathers that mark out the contours of the body are fluffy down feathers that trap body heat – vital at high altitude.

< SCALLOPING

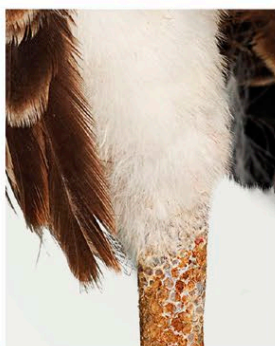
This vulture's dark wing feathers are broadly tipped with lighter marking, giving the bird a scalloped appearance at a distance.



hooked bill

< LEG

Although the bird's upper legs are feathered, its lower legs are bare and so remain relatively clean when the bird is feeding on carcasses.



> A HEAD FOR GORE

Although the sparse down of the vulture's head and neck is frequently blood-stained, a fully feathered head would get clogged with sticky debris as the bird reached deep inside the carcasses of large mammals to feed. The vulture's hooked bill is used to tear semi-rotten flesh, and is long enough to probe carcasses.

< FOOT

Because vultures use their feet for walking rather than killing, they lack the big talons that are typical of predatory birds of prey.



^ WING

Long, broad wings help the vulture soar or glide, saving energy. Takeoff can be a struggle after a heavy meal.



rows of covert feathers smooth passage of air flow

longer, stiffer flight feathers provide thrust and lift for flying